

CEL Activities and Outputs

Community Engaged Learning (CEL) encompasses a broad array of activities that reflect the diverse needs, interests, and aspirations of students and communities alike.

In this resource we share some ideas for activities that you might like to consider embedding in your programme.



Applied Theatre

Students can collaborate to create interactive plays or workshops on topics like diversity or mental health. This hands-on approach fosters empathy and community engagement, empowering participants to share their voices and perspectives.

Business Development

Providing business planning assistance, or marketing support to help launch or grow small businesses.

Campaigns

Students can get involved in advocacy efforts to address social justice issues, such as lobbying for policy changes or raising awareness about environmental sustainability.

Clinics

Providing pro bono legal or business consulting services to individuals or small businesses in need. Under the guidance of experienced professionals, students offer legal advice, draft legal documents, or provide business planning assistance to clients facing various legal or entrepreneurial challenges.

Community based research

Collaborative research projects with community members to address local issues and generate actionable insights. Students work alongside community organisations or residents to identify research questions, collect data, and analyse findings that directly impact the community.

Community organising

Students work alongside grassroots organizations or community leaders to mobilize residents, raise awareness, and organize campaigns or events aimed at achieving social, economic, or environmental justice. Through community organising, students learn valuable leadership and advocacy skills while actively participating in efforts to create positive and sustainable change within their communities.

Conservation

Students can participate in activities such as tree planting, habitat restoration, or waste reduction initiatives to promote environmental sustainability and conservation efforts in their communities.

Consultancy

Providing advice and solutions to organisations or businesses facing specific challenges or seeking opportunities for growth. Students work in teams to conduct research, audits, organisation analysis, development, funding, ideation and develop actionable recommendations tailored to the needs of the client.

Cultural Exchange

Students can organise events or discussions that promote interfaith dialogue, cultural exchange, and understanding among diverse religious and cultural groups within their communities.

Curation

Students can select, organise, and present materials such as artwork, artifacts, or digital content in a cohesive and compelling manner. Through curation, students explore topics of interest, interpret cultural or historical narratives, and communicate ideas to diverse audiences. This hands-on experience allows students to develop skills in research, interpretation, and presentation while fostering creativity and critical thinking. Curation projects may take place in museums, galleries, online platforms, or community spaces, offering students opportunities to engage with diverse audiences and contribute to cultural enrichment.

Desk research

Communities often value the extra capacity of students to undertake comprehensive research to gather information and insights on a specific topic or question. Through desk research, students develop skills in information literacy, critical analysis, and synthesis of findings, contributing to a deeper understanding of complex issues.

Health or education workshops

Students can organise and lead workshops on topics such as nutrition, mental health awareness, sexual health, or substance abuse prevention within their communities.

Event management

Students are able to take on the planning, coordination, and execution of events such as conferences, fundraisers, or community gatherings. Students oversee various aspects of event management, including venue selection, budgeting, marketing, logistics, and on-site coordination.

Language Support

Students with proficiency in multiple languages can offer language support programs for immigrant or refugee communities, helping them improve their language skills and navigate daily life in their new environment.

Live Projects

Typically found in the architecture discipline, students work on projects with tangible outcomes and immediate impact, applying architectural principles, design skills, and technical knowledge to create innovative solutions. Through live projects, students gain hands-on experience in the architectural design process, from conceptualisation to implementation, while considering factors such as functionality, sustainability, and social impact. These projects often involve interdisciplinary collaboration, stakeholder engagement, and community participation, providing students with valuable professional experience and preparing them for careers in architecture and related fields.

Mentoring and Tutoring

Students can serve as mentors or tutors for younger students, providing academic support and guidance in subjects such as math, reading, or science.

Patient engagement

Students can actively involve patients in decision-making processes, gather feedback on healthcare experiences, and co-design interventions or initiatives aimed at improving patient outcomes and experiences. Through patient engagement activities, students develop skills in communication, empathy, and advocacy while promoting patient empowerment, autonomy, and dignity. This hands-on experience allows students to gain insight into the healthcare system, understand the perspectives of diverse patient populations, and contribute to initiatives that prioritise patient-centred care and wellness.

Producing resources and materials

Students can develop content such as brochures, videos, websites, or educational modules that effectively communicate key messages, raise awareness, or provide valuable resources to target audiences.

Public History

Students can engage in projects that bring history to the broader public through exhibitions, documentaries, walking tours, or digital platforms. Students collaborate with historians, community members, and cultural institutions to research, interpret, and present historical narratives in accessible and engaging ways. Through public history projects, students contribute to preserving and sharing local heritage, fostering dialogue about historical events and themes, and promoting cultural understanding and appreciation. This hands-on experience allows students to develop skills in research, storytelling, interpretation, and public presentation, while also making meaningful contributions to public discourse and memory.

Product design and development

Through product design and development projects, students apply principles of design thinking, user-centred design, and market research to create viable and desirable products. This hands-on experience allows students to develop skills in creativity, problem-solving, collaboration, and project management, while also gaining insight into the process of bringing products to market.

Technology and Digital Literacy Training

Students can teach community members basic computer skills, internet literacy, or digital marketing strategies to help bridge the digital divide.

Visual arts and performance

Students can explore forms of creative expression such as visual arts, music, or dance as a means of community engagement and empowerment. Through visual arts and performance projects, students develop skills in creativity, self-expression, communication, and collaboration, while also exploring cultural identity, social issues, and personal growth. This hands-on experience allows students to connect with audiences, evoke emotions, and contribute to cultural enrichment and dialogue within their communities.

Technology and Digital Literacy Training

This can involve hands-on activities such as volunteering at local shelters, food banks, or community gardens, or participating in neighbourhood clean-up initiatives. Through volunteering, students develop a sense of civic responsibility, empathy, and altruism, while also gaining practical experience, expanding their networks, and making meaningful connections with others. Volunteering experience can then be used as a basis for reflection within a CEL module. For example, you can encourage students to identify and reflect on critical incidents or moments during their volunteering experience that challenged their assumptions, beliefs, or expectations; reflect on the experience of specific communities and the implications for their professional practice.

Activity

You can use this framework to start planning your Community Engaged Learning Activities. It is designed to help you reflect on the purpose of your module, the key people or partners that students will be working with, and what activities and outputs students will produce.

1. What is your Community Engaged Learning Module trying to achieve for partners?

Consider the wider value of your module for community partners. What difference is it trying to make? For example: are you providing support? Sharing new ideas or knowledge? Building capacity within organisations?

2. Who are the key people, audience groups or stakeholders that the module will partner?

Think about the key organisations, communities and people that the module will intersect with. What sectors or business types are represented? Are there specific neighbourhoods? What communities or people are represented? Share details around demographics, interests, attitudes and priorities?

3. What activities and outputs will students deliver for partners?

What types of activities and outputs will help your module achieve its aims? How will these be relevant to the people, audiences and stakeholders you are targeting?

4. What is the evidence of need?

What evidence do you have of need for this project? How will you measure success?

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin blue border, intended for the user to provide evidence of need and measurement of success.